

60 YEARS OF FREEDOM

ALTERNATIVE ENERGY

Moushuni | WEST BENGAL



And then there was light

At dusk, Moushuni lights up with the power it gets from its solar plates. This tiny Sunderbans village was green long before it became a global cause.

■ By Swagata Sen

To reach Moushuni, one has to cross two rivers on rickety handmade boats with a jumpy 5-km rickshaw ride in between. Till about six years ago, there was no running water or even a bulb to read under in this small village in the Sunderbans. In an age when most urban Indians come home to almost 300 channels at their beckoning, Moushuni had to do without the luxury of electric power. Now, it gets six hours of electricity every evening, thanks to the two solar plants that were installed here in 2001. From being a no-name entity, Moushuni is today one of the 47 villages in and around the Sunderbans area that run only on alternative energy. "The area Sunderbans now comprises 4 per cent of the world's solar-dependant population—quite a large figure," says S.P. Gon Chowdhury, director, West Bengal Renewable Energy Development Agency (WBREDA). The best thing about solar energy, explains Chowdhury, is that it is maintenance-free.

For the people of Moushuni, who had to live in darkness even 55 years after Independence, Chowdhury is next only to God. "Earlier, we had to cross the river and walk a dozen miles just to get a document photocopied," says Pulak Maity, 49, a schoolteacher. Now the bazaar has a photocopier and a digital studio. The village school is on its way to getting a computer lab. For Rs 75 per three-point and Rs 130 per five-point connection every month, the residents now have the comforts that many people in the rest of the country have long enjoyed—television sets, fans and even refrigerators.

Moushuni has about 2,500 families, a tenth of whom have subscribed to the solar connections. For the students', caretaker Somnath Roy provides extra hours of electricity during examinations. And they have something in store for a rainy day. When there's not enough sun, the plants have gasifiers where they burn twigs with the help of diesel and convert the heat into electricity. Though prolonged cloudy periods leave them with no choice. Each plate runs for 40 years, with a change of batteries needed every seven years. Life at Moushuni is fluctuation-free and as natural as it can possibly get. As the last boat sails away from the island, a tiny bulb lights up near its shore. And as you leave, Moushuni glitters in the distance.



RAW POWER: Children play near the solar plates